
The Global Burden of Mental Illness: Prevalence, Impact, and the Treatment Gap

A data-driven overview of global mental health conditions,
their disease burden, and the persistent gap between need and treatment.

DATA SOURCE

Our World in Data

DATE

2023

CONFIDENTIAL

 **KEY INSIGHT** Mental health conditions span from common to severe, necessitating priority policy focus due to massive global impact.



1 in 3

Women

will experience major depression
in their lifetime.



1 in 5

Men

will experience major depression
in their lifetime.

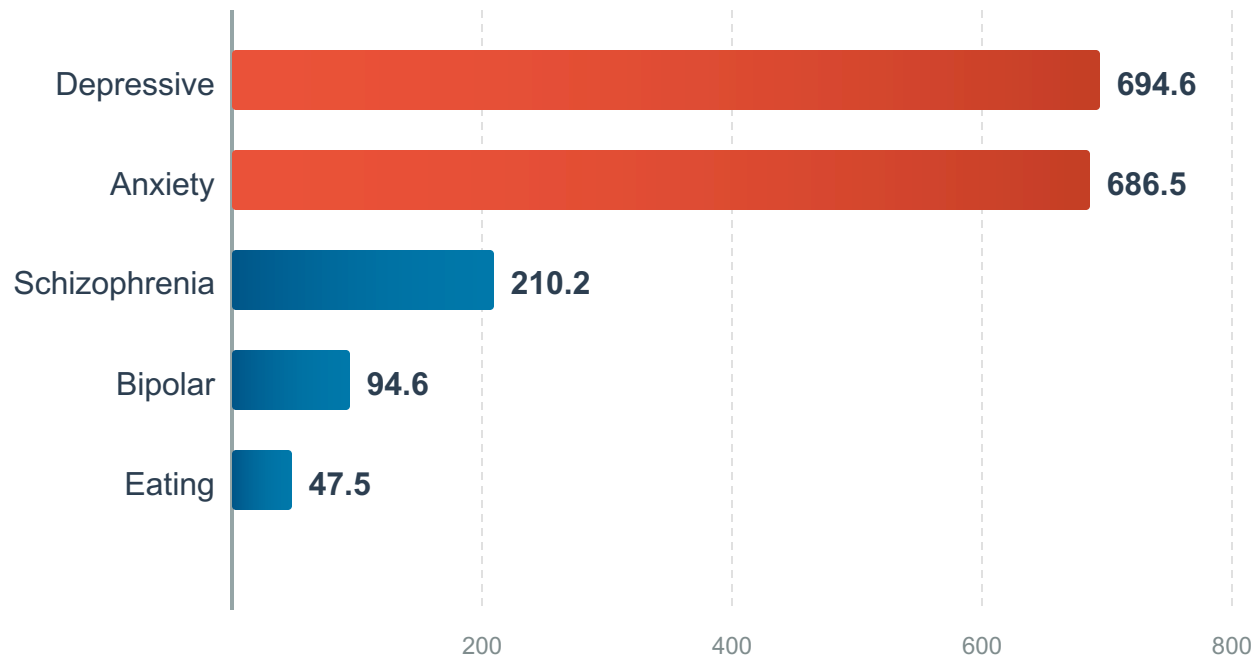
Why Mental Health Matters for Society

Poor mental health profoundly affects individual well-being, the ability to work, and community relationships.
Other conditions like schizophrenia and bipolar disorder are less common but severely impact individuals' lives.

KEY INSIGHT Combined, depression and anxiety account for ~80% of the total burden across these five major categories.

Burden of Disease by Category

(Disability-Adjusted Life Years per 100,000 people, World 2023)



Strategic Implications



Overwhelming Majority

Common conditions (depression and anxiety) create the vast majority of disease burden at a population level.



Policy Prioritization

Interventions targeting these two conditions offer the highest potential return on investment for broad public health improvements.

 KEY INSIGHT

Together they account for the vast majority of mental health burden, dwarfing all other categories.

Depressive Disorders

694.6

DALYs per 100,000



NEAR PARITY

Anxiety Disorders

686.5

DALYs per 100,000



KEY INSIGHT While population-level burden is lower than depression, individual severity and disability remain extremely high.

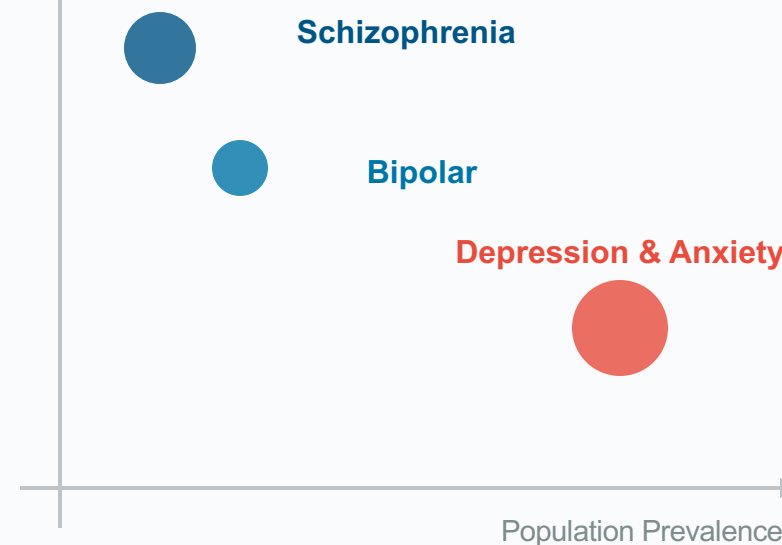
DALYs per 100,000

Schizophrenia **210.2**
Disproportionately high individual burden

Bipolar Disorder **94.6**
Significant life impact

Though smaller in absolute numbers than depression, the per-patient severity is immense.

Individual Severity



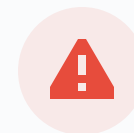
KEY INSIGHT

Mental illnesses are treatable, yet significant barriers create a persistent gap between need and care.



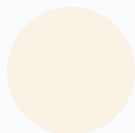
Stigma & Disclosure

Many people are uncomfortable disclosing symptoms to healthcare professionals or even to people they know well.



Lack of Access

Basic treatment is often lacking, especially in low- and middle-income countries where resources are scarce.



Poor Quality of Care

Even where treatment infrastructure exists, the quality of care provided may be inadequate or outdated.



Data Challenges

Underreporting due to stigma obscures true prevalence; the actual burden is likely much higher than figures suggest.

KEY INSIGHT Responses vary widely by culture and economy, meaning policy interventions must avoid a one-size-fits-all approach.

Taking Prescribed Medication

Most common in higher-income settings where healthcare access is established.



Religious / Spiritual Activities

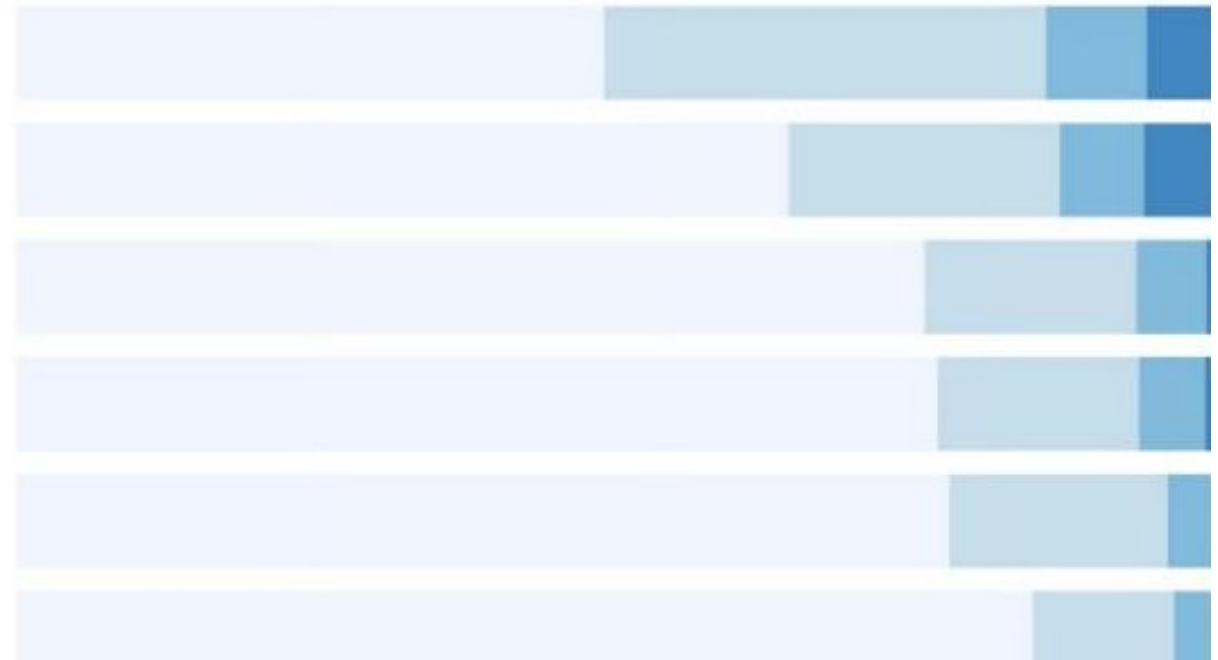
Highly prevalent in many regions worldwide as a primary coping mechanism.



Talking to Friends or Family

A universally reported and widely accessible social support mechanism.

Coping Strategies Across Countries



 **KEY INSIGHT** Policy should scale interventions for common disorders while maintaining specialized care for severe conditions.

- 1 **Depression and anxiety represent the overwhelming majority** of mental health DALYs.
- 2 **Schizophrenia and bipolar** carry a disproportionate individual burden despite lower prevalence.
- 3 **Treatment exists** but access and quality remain broadly inadequate across global settings.
- 4 **Stigma consistently suppresses** both help-seeking behavior and accurate prevalence data.
- 5 **Policy must prioritize** scaling evidence-based interventions for common mental disorders.